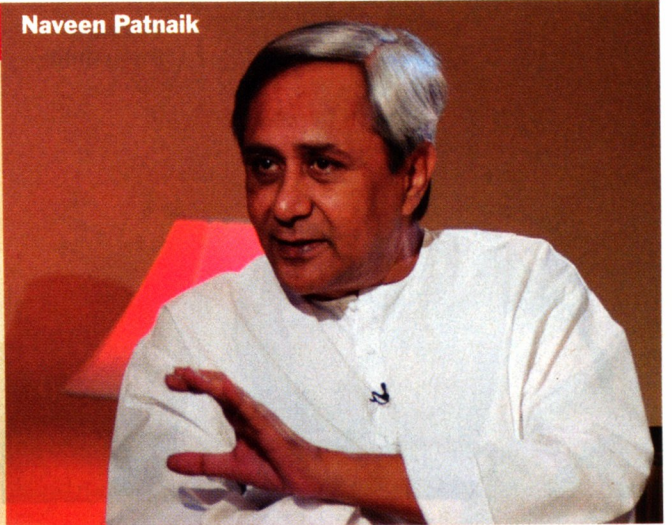


BIJU JANATA DAL

Orissa

- Rs 850-crore special farmers' package and a Rs 100-crore rural electrification scheme for villages.
- Housing scheme for scs/sts, who form 38 per cent of the state's population.
- DA for government servants raised by 6 per cent; 36,000 posts, which have been lying vacant for years in various government departments, to be filled.

Naveen Patnaik



severe criticism of wheat imports at almost double the domestic MSP has made the ruling alliance reconsider its pricing policy. Such poll-oriented policy initiatives have now become the order of the day, but instead of reforming the distribution system, they only add to the burden of the public exchequer.

It's easy to make promises if you don't have to pick up the tab. While the Centre announces, on average, three major sops every week, politicians at the state level are striving hard to outsmart one another. Nowhere is this more evident than in Andhra Pradesh, where Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy and TDP's N. Chandrababu Naidu

are trying to beat each other at the sop game. So while Reddy stunned Naidu by saying that he was toying with the idea of giving rice at Rs 2 per kg—the scheme that catapulted Naidu's father-in-law, the late N.T. Rama Rao, to power for the first time in 1983—the TDP chief hit back by promising free power to farmers, housing for middle income groups and subsidised garments for the poor. Both leaders conveniently glossed over the immense strain such schemes put on the exchequer.

In Punjab, where polls and populist measures are inextricably linked, the talk of a mid-term poll has already prompted the ruling Shiromani Akali Dal to pamper its

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